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WEB 4

Meta Ads for Complete Beginners

Publish your first ad, step by step.

No experience needed. Follow each step exactly as written: what to click, what to type, and what to leave alone.

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WEB4 Digital Systems

Based on Meta Ads Manager as it looks in November 2026.
Meta changes its screens often. If something looks a little different, look for the same words.

Before you start

Get these five things ready first. It takes 5 minutes, and it saves you from getting stuck halfway.

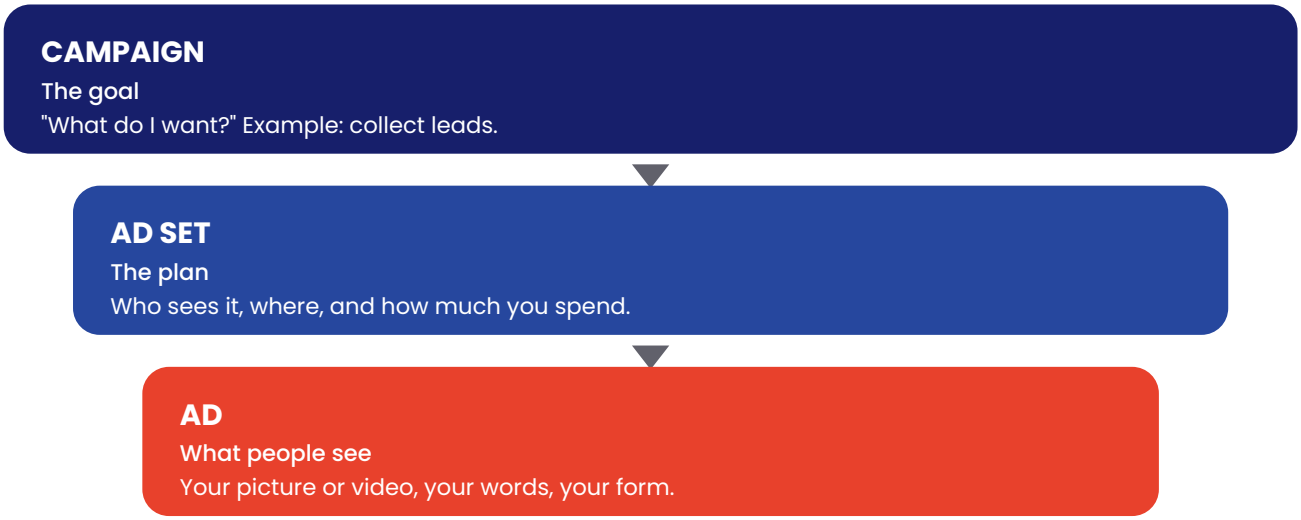
1. **A Facebook account and a Facebook Page for your business.**
   Your ad runs in the name of your Page.
2. **A way to pay that works.**
   Add a debit card or virtual card to your ad account. (Mastercard or Visa, if it keeps getting rejected contact your bank.
3. **Your ad picture, ready on your computer.**
   A vertical picture works best, for example 1080x1350 pixels.
4. **A link to your privacy policy page.**
   Meta asks for this when you build the sign-up form., if you need help with this contact us.
5. **A laptop or desktop computer.**
   It is much easier than a phone for your first ad, but if you must use a phone, then request desktop version of website in settings.

HOW LONG WILL THIS TAKE?
Building and publishing the ad: about 10 minutes.

After you publish, Meta reviews your ad. Most ads are reviewed within 24 hours, and some take longer. So your ad may not go live right away. This is normal.

The big picture in one minute

Every Meta ad has three levels. You will fill in one level at a time, and Ads Manager walks you through them in this order.



Think of it like folders: 1 campaign holds many ad sets, and 1 ad set holds many ads.

That is all you need to know. Now let us build your first ad.

STEP 1

Open Ads Manager

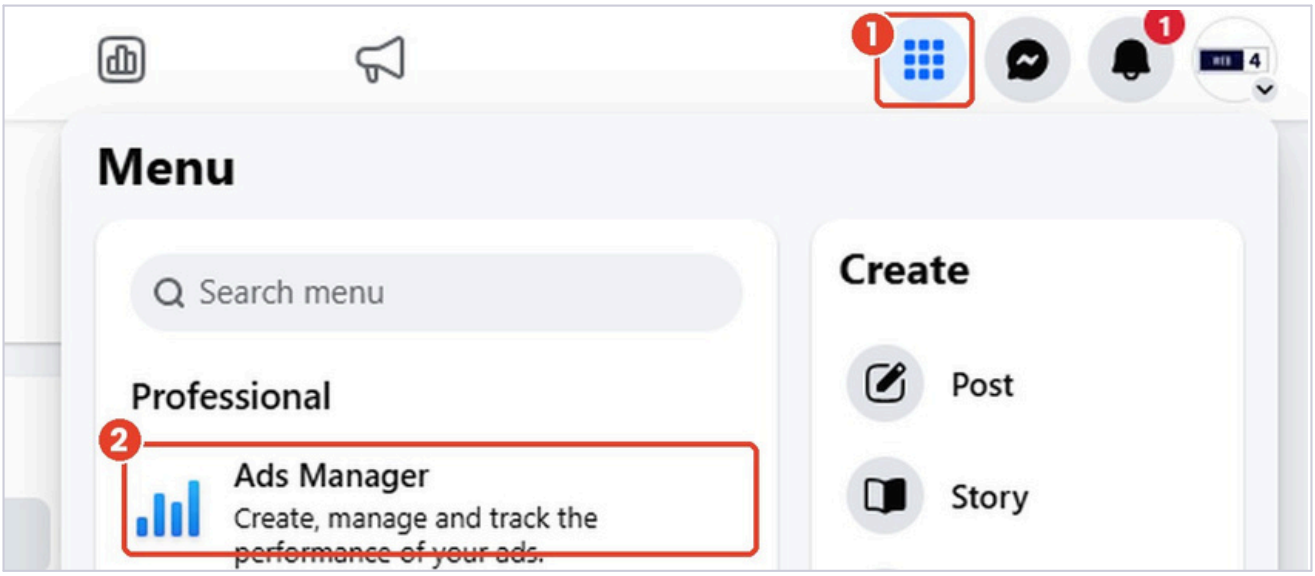
Ads Manager is the dashboard where you build your ads.

There are three ways to get in. I recommend the third one.

Way 1: Search for it. Search "Meta Ads Manager" on Google. It is quick, but if you have more than one Facebook account, you can land in the wrong one.

Way 2: Meta Business Suite. Safer, because you pick your business first.

Way 3: Through Facebook (my favourite, and the quickest). Open Facebook on your computer. At the top right, click the menu icon (the nine dots). Then click **Ads Manager**.



1. Click the menu icon (nine dots) at the top right of Facebook.
2. Click Ads Manager.

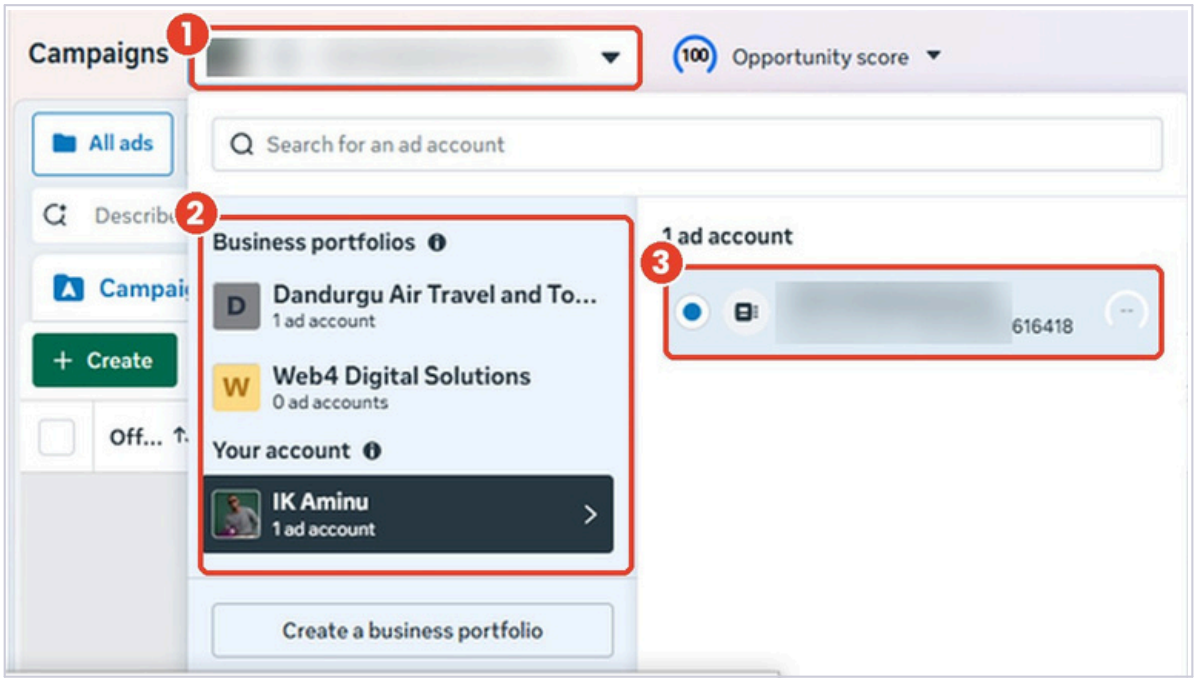
Wait a few seconds while it says "Loading your ad account". Do not click anything until it finishes.

> **DON'T**
> Do not use the Facebook mobile app for your first ad. The screens are different and it is easy to get lost. If you must use a phone use method 2 and request desktop site.

STEP 2

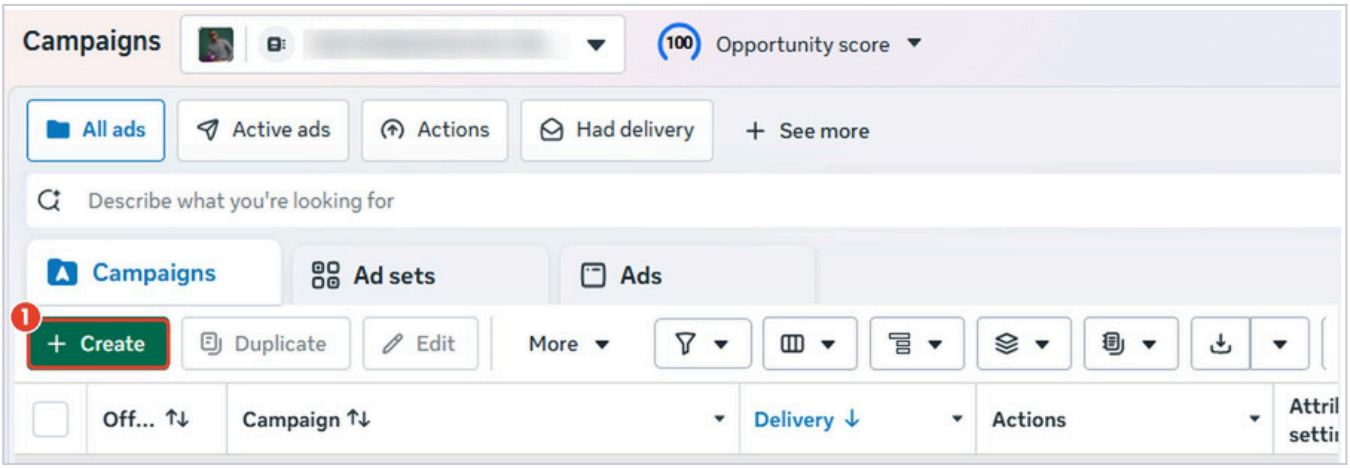
Check you are in the right account

At the top left, next to the word **Campaigns**, you will see your ad account. Make sure it is the right one for your business. If you manage more than one business, this step matters, because the money is charged to the account you pick.



1. Click the account drop-down at the top.
2. Pick the right business portfolio on the left.
3. Pick the right ad account on the right.

Let the page load. Then click the green **Create** button to start a new campaign.



1. Click the green Create button.

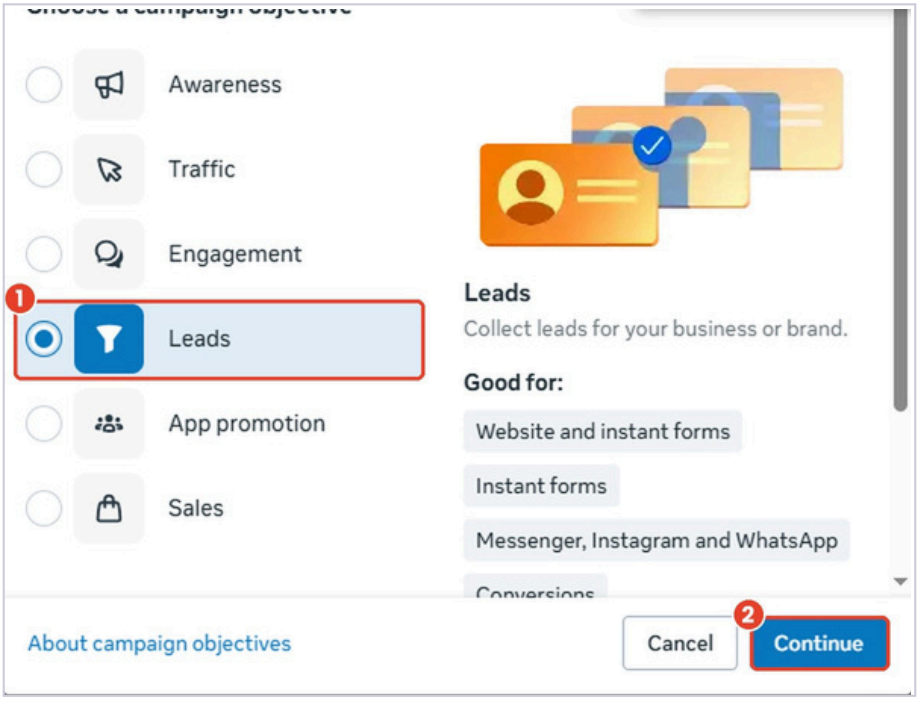
STEP 3

Choose your objective

A window opens. Meta asks what the goal of your campaign is. Pick the one that matches what you want:

Objective	Pick it when you want...
Awareness	as many people as possible to see your brand or product
Traffic	people to visit your website
Engagement	likes, comments and messages
Leads	people to give you their contact details
App promotion	people to install your app
Sales	people to buy from your website

For this guide, choose **Leads**. Leave "Buying type" as **Auction**. Then click **Continue**.



1. Click Leads.
2. Click Continue (bottom right).

GOOD TO KNOW
A "lead" is a person who gives you their name and phone number because they are interested in what you sell.

STEP 4

Set up the campaign and your budget

A new page opens. Here is what to do, from top to bottom:

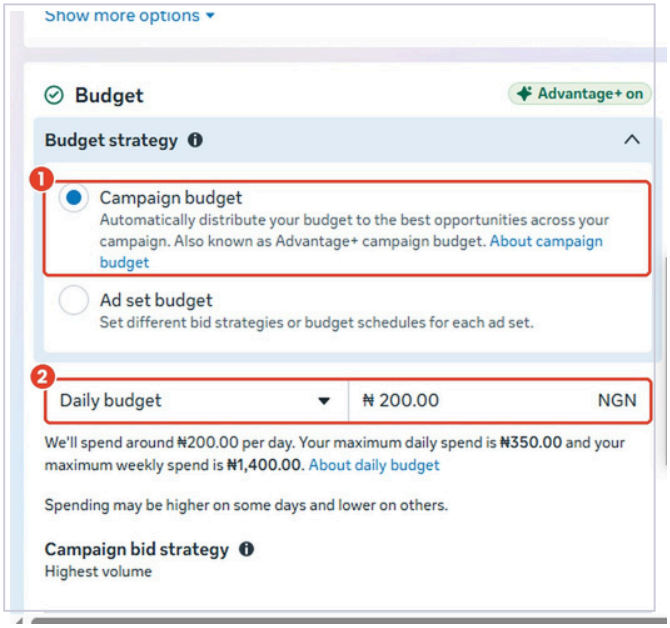
Campaign name: Change it to something you will recognise later, for example "Umrah - Leads - November".

Special ad categories: Leave it as it is. The only time you must change it is if your ad is about financial/credit products and services, jobs, housing, or social issues, elections or politics. If it is, choose that category.

A/B test: Leave it off. Do not turn it on if you do not know what it does.

Budget strategy: Leave it on **Campaign budget**. Meta then spreads your money to where it works best. Do not choose Ad set budget.

Daily budget: Type how much you want to spend per day, in Naira. Example: 5,000.



1. Campaign budget stays selected.
2. Choose "Daily budget" and type your amount.

Campaign bid strategy: Leave it on "Highest volume". Then click **Next** at the bottom right.

Meta uses your daily budget as an average. On a good day it can spend up to 75% more than your daily budget, and less on other days. But in one week (Sunday to Saturday) it will never spend more than 7 times your daily budget.

Your daily budget	Most Meta can spend in 1 day	Most Meta can spend in 1 week
₦2,000	₦3,500	₦14,000
₦5,000	₦8,750	₦35,000
₦10,000	₦17,500	₦70,000

DON'T
Do not type a budget you cannot afford to lose. Start small, then raise it once you see leads coming in.

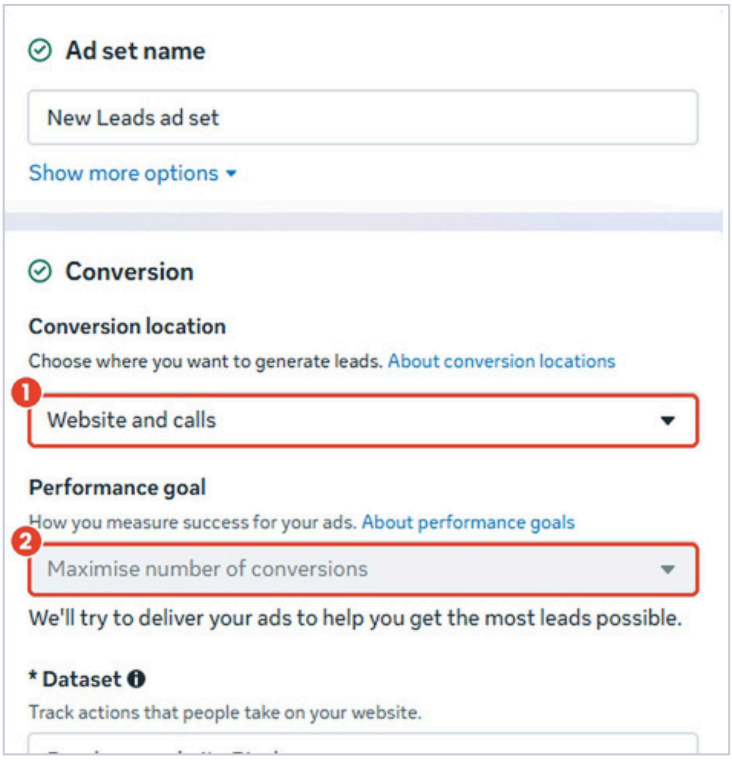
STEP 5

Choose where leads come from

Now you are on the ad set page. Give the ad set a name if you like. Then scroll to **Conversion**.

Conversion location: Meta may show **Website and calls** by default, as in the screenshot. Change it to **Instant forms**. An instant form is a short sign-up form that opens inside Facebook, so people never leave the app.

Performance goal: After you choose Instant forms, pick **Maximise number of leads**.



1. Open this drop-down and change it to Instant forms.
2. Then set the Performance goal to Maximise number of leads.

Facebook Page: If Meta asks, choose the Facebook Page that will run the ad.

Dataset: Ignore this. Datasets (they used to be called Pixels) are only needed when you send people to a website. You are using a form, so you do not need one.

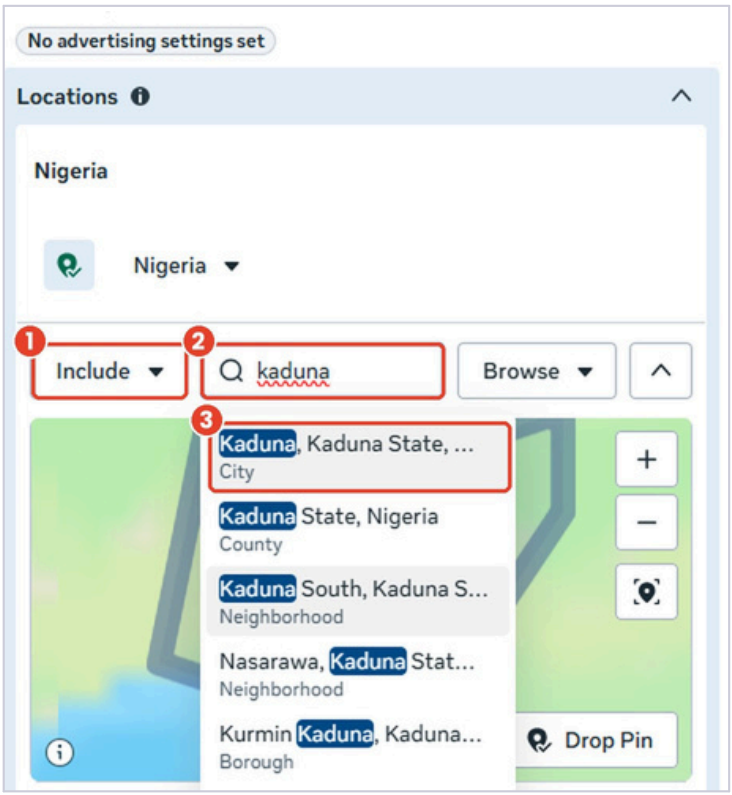
Dynamic creative: If you see this switch, leave it off.

> **DON'T**
> Do not choose Website or Calls for your first ad. They need extra setup (a dataset and links) that you do not need.
> Do not choose "Qualified leads" as your goal. It needs extra tracking software.

STEP 6

Choose who sees your ad

Scroll down to **Audience** and then **Locations**. Meta may start with the whole country. Change it to the places where your customers actually live.



1. "Include" means show the ad here. "Exclude" means never show it here.
2. Type the place name in the search box.
3. Click the right result. Check the label: City, County (state) and Neighborhood are different.

Age and gender: Set the ages and gender that match your customers. Click the little pencil icon next to each one to edit it.

Detailed targeting: Here you add the interests, behaviours and details of your ideal customer. For example: people interested in travel, or in Fashion content. So before you do this step, ask yourself: Who is my customer? What do they like? What do they do? Who are they?

HOW META TREATS YOUR CHOICES NOW

Meta only treats location, minimum age, language and exclusions as strict rules. Your age range, gender and interests are treated as hints. Meta starts with them, but may also show your ad to other people it thinks will respond.

So choose your location carefully, and do not worry if some leads fall slightly outside your age range.

STEP 7

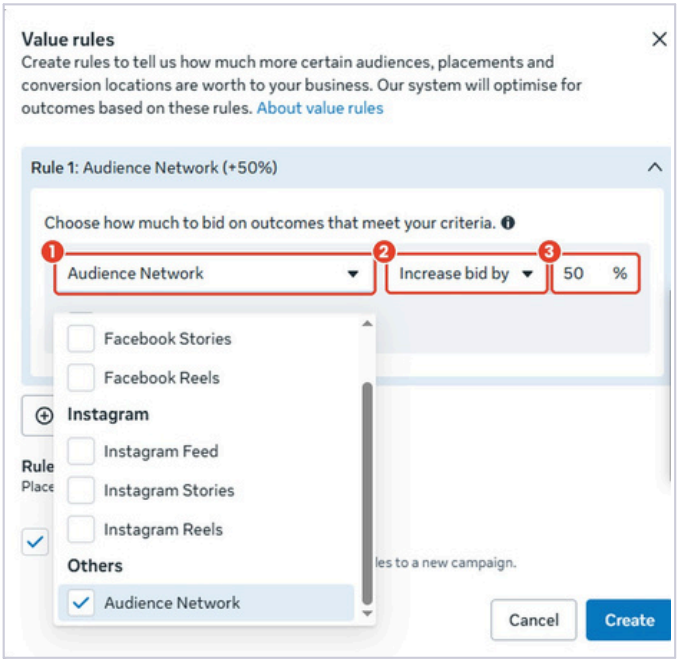
Turn off Audience Network

MY RULE
Audience Network shows your ad inside other people's apps and websites. For lead ads I always switch it off. In my experience, most leads from there are junk or bots, and they eat your budget without giving you real customers. The only time I leave it on is for an Awareness campaign, where I just want the most people possible to see my logo.

In Leads campaigns, Meta no longer lets you untick placements inside the ad set. So use these two methods. Method B is stronger because it blocks Audience Network for every campaign in your account.

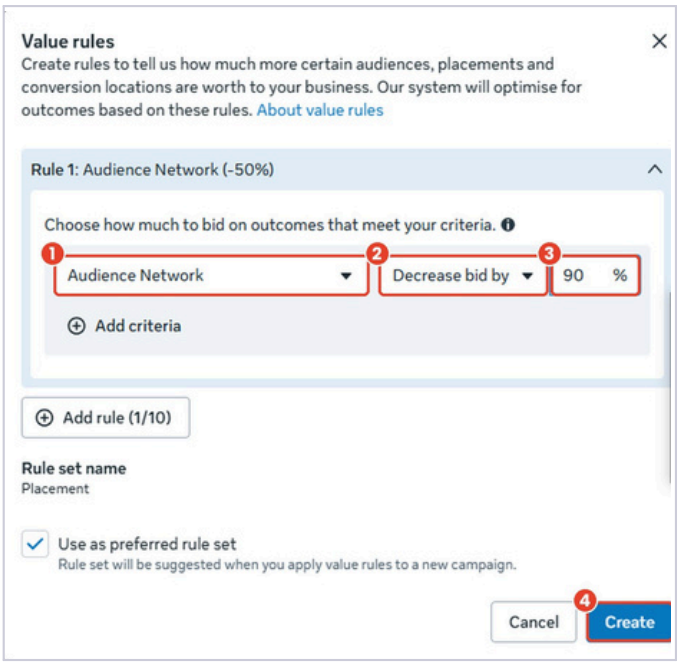
Method A: Value rules (for this ad set)

Find **Value rules** in the ad set and add a new rule. Open the first drop-down and choose **Audience Network** (it is at the bottom, under "Others").



1. Choose Audience Network here.
2. Change "Increase bid by"...
3. ...to "Decrease bid by". The box shows 50 now; you will change it next.

Change it to **Decrease bid by**, type **90**, and click **Create**. Meta will now bid 90% less for Audience Network, so it gets almost nothing.



1. Choose Audience Network.
2. Choose "Decrease bid by".
3. Type 90.
4. Click Create.

Method B: Block it for the whole account

Go to Ads Manager **Advertising settings**, then **Account controls**, then **Placement controls**. Switch on **"My business can only advertise on specific placements"**. Untick **Audience Network native, banner and interstitial** and **Audience Network rewarded videos**. Click **Confirm**. You only do this once.

> **DON'T**
> Do not leave Audience Network on for lead campaigns. Not even "just to test".

STEP 8

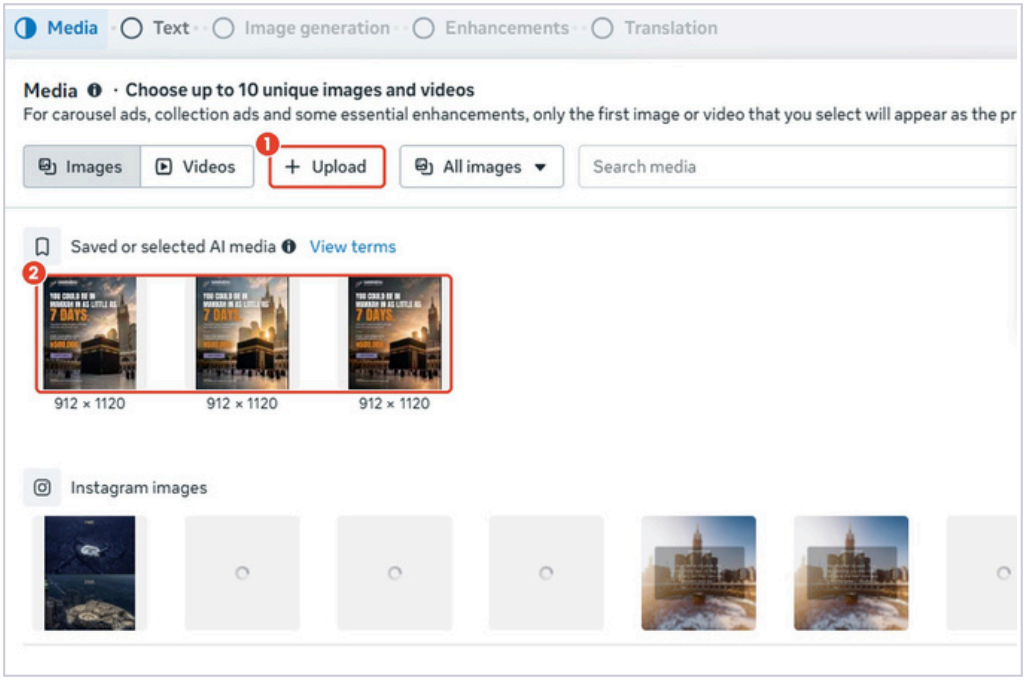
Create your ad

The picture and words people will see.

Click **Next** to move to the ad level. You will see "New Leads ad".

Ad name: Give it a name you will recognise. **Facebook Page:** Choose the Page that will promote the ad. **Format:** Choose **single image or video** (a carousel is a set of swipeable pictures; skip it for now). Then click **Set up creative**.

A window opens with the tabs **Media** and **Text** at the top. On the Media tab, click **Upload** and choose your picture, or click a picture you uploaded before.



1. Click Upload to add a new picture or video.
2. Or click a picture you have used before. Then click Next (bottom right).

Next, the **Text** tab:

Primary text is the words above your picture. Say what you offer, who it is for, and what to do next. Keep it short. Example: "Want to go on vacation in 7 days? Tap Apply now. We will arrange it for you."

Headline is the bold line under the picture. Keep it to a few words.

Call to action is the button. Choose the one that fits, such as Sign up or Apply now.

SKIP or TURN OFF the Image generation, Enhancements and Translation tabs for your first ad.

> **DO**
> Use one clear, sharp picture.
> Check your spelling. Mistakes make people not trust you.

STEP 9

Build your instant form

Scroll to the **Instant form** section of your ad and click **Create instant form**. Work through it in this order:

1. Form name. Anything you will recognise.
2. Form type. Choose one:
More volume: more leads, but lower quality on average. People can submit very fast.

Higher intent: fewer leads, but better quality on average. People see a review screen and confirm their details before sending, so the ones who submit are more serious. (This type only shows in Facebook and Instagram feeds on mobile.)

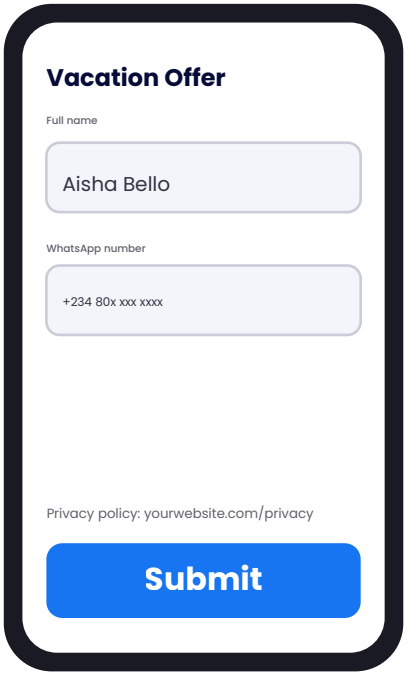
If you want to sell, I suggest **Higher intent**. If you only want as many names as possible, choose More volume.

3. Questions. Ask as little as you can. Every extra question makes fewer people finish the form, because giving away information feels like a privacy risk. For a simple product, ask for **Full name** and **WhatsApp number**.

Choose "WhatsApp number" rather than only "Phone number". In Nigeria, WhatsApp is much more reliable.

4. Privacy policy. Paste your privacy policy link and give it a name. This is required.

5. Thank-you screen. Tell people what happens next. Example: "Thank you! We will message you on WhatsApp within 24 hours."



Example of the form people will see on their phone.

WHY SOME EXTRA QUESTIONS CAN HELP
More questions means fewer leads, but the people who finish are usually more serious. Think of it as a sieve. Read up on what qualifications questions are. For your first ad, keep it simple.
A form can hold up to 15 questions in total.

When you are done, click **Publish** on the form (or Save). Check that your new form is selected in the ad.

DON'T
Do not ask for things Meta does not allow, such as income, health details, religion or ID numbers. Meta will block the ad.

STEP 10

Check everything, then publish

Click **Review** at the top (next to Edit) and go through this list. Take your time. A small mistake here can waste your budget.

FINAL CHECK

Objective is Leads, and conversion location is Instant forms.

Location is correct, and Audience Network is off.

Daily budget is the amount you want.

The right Facebook Page is selected.

The picture and words have no spelling mistakes.

The form asks only what you need, and the privacy policy link opens.

Now click **Publish** at the bottom right. If the button is grey, check the right-hand panel for a red message. See the troubleshooting page next.

What happens after you publish

Your ad goes into review. Most ads are approved within 24 hours, though some take longer. Do not keep editing the ad while it is in review, because changes can restart the review.

Where your leads go. Open Ads Manager, or Meta Business Suite and its Leads Center, to see and download your leads. Meta only lets you download a lead for up to 90 days after it was submitted, so download often.

Reply fast.

Message new leads on WhatsApp as soon as you can.

Speed makes a big difference.

Be patient. Give the ad at least 5 to 7 days before you decide if it works. Do not judge it after one day.

CONGRATULATIONS

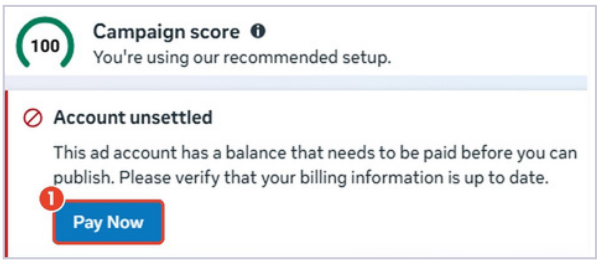
If you have got this far, you have built and published your first Meta lead ad.

Stuck? Fix it here

The most common things that stop a new ad, and how to fix them.

"Account unsettled"

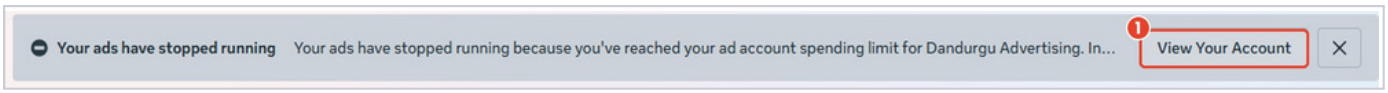
This means your ad account has a balance that must be paid before you can publish. Click **Pay Now** and check that your billing information is correct.



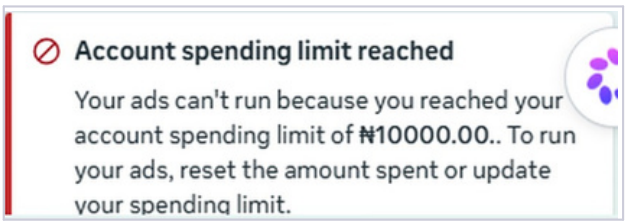
1. Click Pay Now.

"Your ads have stopped running" or "Account spending limit reached"

Every ad account can have a spending limit. When your ads reach it, they stop. Click **View Your Account**, open Billing, find **Account spending limit**, and reset it or raise it.



1. Click View Your Account.



You may also see this red message on the right side while you build your ad. It means the same thing: your limit was reached.

Other problems

What you see	What to do
"Payment error" in the Delivery column	Your card was declined. Update your payment method in Billing, or try another card.
The Publish button is grey	Look at the right-hand panel for a red message and fix it. Also check that no required box is empty.
The ad is "In review" for a long time	Wait 24 hours. If it is still stuck after 48 hours, request another review.
Many leads give wrong phone numbers	Use the Higher intent form type and ask for the WhatsApp number.
You cannot find the leads	Check Ads Manager, or Meta Business Suite and Leads Center. Remember the 90-day download limit.

One-page cheat sheet

Setting	Whatto do
Objective	Choose Leads
Budget strategy	Leave on Campaign budget
Daily budget	Type your amount
Special ad categories	Leave alone (unless it applies to you)
A/B test	Leave off
Conversion location	Change to Instant forms
Performance goal	Maximise number of leads
Locations	Pick your real customer locations
Audience Network	Turn off (value rule, and account controls)
Form type	Higher intent (to sell) or More volume
Questions	Full name + WhatsApp number
Privacy policy	Add your link (required)

ALWAYS

Use a computer for your first ad.
Check you are in the right ad account.
Ask for as little as you can on the form.
Message new leads fast, on WhatsApp.
Wait 5 to 7 days before judging results.

DON'T

Do not turn on A/B tests until you know what they do.
Do not choose Ad set budget as a beginner.
Do not leave Audience Network on for lead ads.
Do not edit your ad while it is in review.
Do not spend money you cannot afford to lose.

Words you will see

Campaign	The top level. It holds your goal.
Ad set	The middle level. It holds your audience, budget and places.
Ad / creative	The picture or video and words people see.
Lead	Someone who gives you their contact details.
Instant form	A sign-up form that opens inside Facebook or Instagram.
Dataset (Pixel)	A tracking tool for websites. Not needed for instant forms.

Need help running your ads? Visit **ikaminu.cc.cd**.